

0.0.1 The Stilling of Thoughts

vitakkasaṇṭhānasuttaṃ

1. Thus was heard by me. At one time the Auspicious One was dwelling at Savatthi in Jeta's Grove, Anathapindika's Park. At that place the Auspicious One addressed the bhikkhus: "Bhikkhus." "Bhante," those bhikkhus replied to the Auspicious One. The Auspicious One said this:

evaṃ me sutam: ekaṃ samayaṃ bhagavā sāvattiyā viharati jetavane anāthapiṇḍikassa ārāme. tatra kho bhagavā bhikkhū āmantesi bhikkhavoti. bhadanteti te bhikkhū bhagavato paccassosum. bhagavā etadavoca:

2. For a bhikkhu devoted to the higher mind, O bhikkhus, he should pay attention to five signs from time to time. What five?

adhicittamanuyuttena bhikkhave bhikkhunā pañca nimittāni kālena kālaṃ manasikātabbāni. kāmāni pañca?

3. Here, O bhikkhus, for a bhikkhu, whatever sign owing to the attention of which there arises evil, unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then, O bhik-

khus, that bhikkhu should attend to some other sign connected with the wholesome. From his [withdrawal] from that sign and attention to some other sign connected with the wholesome, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

idha bhikkhave bhikkhunā yaṃ nimittaṃ āgamma yaṃ nimittaṃ manasikaroto uppajjanti pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā tamhā nimittā aññaṃ nimittaṃ manasikātabbaṃ kusālūpasamhitam. tassa tamhā nimittā aññaṃ nimittam manasikaroto kusālūpasamhitam, ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te pahīyanti. te abbhattham gacchanti. tesam pahānā ajjhattameva cittam santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti¹, samādhīyati.

4. Just as, O bhikkhus, a skilled carpenter or a carpenter's apprentice having used a very tiny peg, would knock out a grosser peg. So too, O bhikkhus, for a bhikkhu, whatever sign owing to the attention of which there arises evil, unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with

¹hosi - machasaṃ■

delusion, then, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu should attend to some other sign connected with the wholesome. From his [withdrawal] from that sign and attention to some other sign connected with the wholesome, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

seyyathāpi bhikkhave dakkho palagaṇḍo vā palagaṇḍantevāsī vā sukhumāya āṇiyā oḷārikam āṇim abhinihaneyya² abhinihareyya abhinivajjeyya³ evameva kho bhikkhave bhikkhuno yaṃ nimittam āgamma yaṃ nimittam manasikaroto uppajjanti pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā tamhā nimittā aññaṃ nimittam manasikātabbam kusālūpasamhitam. ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi te pahīyanti. te abbattham gacchanti. tesam pahānā ajjhattameva cittam santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhiyati.

5. If, O bhikkhus, from that bhikkhu's [withdrawal] from that sign and attention to some other sign connected with the wholesome, there still arises evil unwholesome

²abhinihaneyya - machasam

³abhinivatteyya - machasam

thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu should investigate the danger in those thoughts thus: “These thoughts are indeed unwholesome. These thoughts are indeed blameworthy. These thoughts indeed ripen in suffering.” Of him investigating the danger of those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

tassa ce bhikkhave bhikkhuno tamhā nimittā añ-
ñam nimittam manasikaroto kusalūpasamhitam
uppajjanteva pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpa-
samhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena
bhikkhave bhikkhunā tesam vitakkānam ādīnavo
upaparikkhitabbo: itipime vitakkā akusalā, itipime
vitakkā sāvajjā, itipime vitakkā dukkhavipākāti.
tassa tesam vitakkānam ādīnavam upaparikkhato
ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi do-
sūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te pahīyanti. te
abbhattham gacchanti, tesam pahānā ajjhattameva
cittam santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhi-
yati.

6. Just as, O bhikkhus, a woman or man, young in years, a youth, fond of adornments, would be troubled, humiliated and disgusted at the corpse of a snake, a

corpse of a dog, or a corpse of a human being strung around his or her neck. So too, O bhikkhus, if from that bhikkhu's [withdrawal] from that sign and attention to some other sign connected with the wholesome, there still arises evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu should investigate the danger in those thoughts thus: "These thoughts are indeed unwholesome. These thoughts are indeed blameworthy. These thoughts indeed ripen in suffering." Of him investigating the danger of those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

seyyathāpi bhikkhave itthī vā vā puriso vā daharo yuvā maṇḍanakajātiko ahikuṇapena vā kukkura-kuṇapena vā manussakuṇapena vā kaṇṭhe āsat-tena aṭṭiyeyya harāyeyya jiguccheyya, evameva kho bhikkhave tassa ce bhikkhuno tamhāpi⁴ nimittā aññaṃ nimittaṃ manasikaroto kusalūpasam-hitam uppajjanteva pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā tesam vitakkānaṃ ādīnavo upaparikkhitabbo: itipime vitakkā akusalā, itipime vitakkā sāvajjā, itipime vitakkā dukkhavi-

⁴tamhā va - syā ■

pākāti. tassa tesam vitakkānam ādīnavam upa-
parikkhato ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpa-
saṃhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te
pahīyanti. te abbattham gacchanti tesam pa-
hānā ajjhattameva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati
ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

7. If, O bhikkhus, for that bhikkhu investigating the danger of those thoughts, there still arises evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu should engage in not being mindful, not attending to those thoughts. Of him engaging in not being mindful, not attending to those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

tassa ce bhikkhave bhikkhuno tesam⁵ vitakkānam
ādīnavam upaparikkhato uppajjanteva pāpakā aku-
salā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi
mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā te-
sam⁶ vitakkānam asati amanasikāro āpajjitabbo.
tassa tesam vitakkānam asati amanasikāram āpaj-
jato ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhi-

⁵tesampi - machasam ■

⁶tesam yeva avi ■

tāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te pahīyanti. te abbattham gacchanti. tesam pahānā ajjhattameva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

8. Just as, O bhikkhus, a man endowed with eyes wishing not to see forms that have come into his range would close his eyes or would look elsewhere. So too, O bhikkhus, if for that bhikkhu investigating the danger of those thoughts, there still arises evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu should engage in not being mindful, not attending to those thoughts. Of him engaging in not being mindful, not attending to those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

seyyathāpi bhikkhave cakkhumā puriso āpāthagatānaṃ rūpānaṃ adassanakāmo assa, so nimīleyya⁷ vā aññena vā apalokeyya. evameva kho bhikkhave tassa ce bhikkhuno tesampi vitakkānaṃ ādīnavaṃ upaparikkhato uppajjanteva pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā tesam vitakkānaṃ asati amanasikāro āpajjitabbo.

⁷nimmileyyā - syā

tassa tesam vitakkānaṃ asati amanasikāraṃ āpajjato ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi

9. If, O bhikkhus, for that bhikkhu engaging in not being mindful, not attending to those thoughts, there still arises evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu should pay attention to stilling the thought activities of those thoughts. Of him paying attention to stilling the thought activities of those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

tassa ce bhikkhave bhikkhuno tesampi vitakkānaṃ asati amanasikāraṃ āpajjato uppajjanteva pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā tesam vitakkānaṃ vitakkasaṅkhārasaṅghānaṃ⁸ manasi kātabbaṃ tassa tesam vitakkānaṃ vitakkasaṅkhārasaṅghānaṃ manasikaroto ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te pahīyanti te

⁸vitakka saṅkhāra santhānaṃ - syā. atthakathā 'tena bhikkhave -pe- mohūpasamhitāpi' pāṭhoyaṃ marammachatthasaṅgītipiṭakapotthake na disate ■

abbhattham gacchanti. tesam pahānā ajjhata-meva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

10. Just as, O bhikkhus, it might occur to a man moving quickly thus: “Why am I moving quickly? What if I were to move slowly?” While moving slowly it might occur to him thus: “Why am I moving slowly? What if I were to stand still?” While standing still it might occur to him thus: “Why am I standing still? What if I were to sit down?” While sitting down it might occur to him thus: “Why am I sitting down? What if I were to lie down?” Then he lies down. Thus, O bhikkhus, that man having left behind grosser and grosser postures, would fashion subtler and subtler postures. So too, O bhikkhus, if for that bhikkhu engaging in not being mindful, not attending to those thoughts, there still arises evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu should pay attention to stilling the thought activities of those thoughts. Of him paying attention to stilling the thought activities of those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

seyyathāpi bhikkhave puriso sīgham gaccheyya,

tassa evamassa: kinnu kho ahaṃ sīghaṃ gacchāmi, yannūnāhaṃ saṇikaṃ gaccheyyanti. so saṇikaṃ gaccheyya. tassa evamassa: kinnu kho ahaṃ saṇikaṃ gacchāmi, yannūnāhaṃ tiṭṭheyyanti. so tiṭṭheyya. tassa evamassa: kinnu kho ahaṃ ṭhito yannūnāhaṃ nisīdeyyanti.,so nisīdeyya. tassa evamassa: kinnu kho ahaṃ nisinno, yannūnāhaṃ nipajjeyyanti. so nipajjeyya. evaṃ hi so bhikkhave puriso oḷārikaṃ oḷārikaṃ iriyāpathaṃ abhinivajjetvā⁹ sukhumaṃ sukhumaṃ iriyāpathaṃ kappeyya. evameva kho bhikkhave tassa ce bhikkhuno tesampi vitakkānaṃ asati amanasikāraṃ āpajjato uppajjanteva pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā tesam vitakkānaṃ vitakkasaṅkhārasaṅṭhānaṃ manasikātabbaṃ. tassa tesam vitakkānaṃ vitakkasaṅkhārasaṅṭhānaṃ manasikaroto ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te pahīyanti te abbhataṃ gacchanti. tesam pahānā ajjhataṃ eva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

11. If, O bhikkhus, for that bhikkhu paying attention to stilling the thought activities of those thoughts, there still arises evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu, having clenched

⁹abhinissajjetvā - syā

the teeth together, having pressed the tongue against the palate, should forcibly restrain, completely crush down, overwhelm mental states with mental states. Of him having clenched the teeth together, having pressed the tongue against the palate, forcibly restraining, completely crushing down, overwhelming mental states with mental states, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

tassa ce bhikkhave bhikkhuno tesampi vitakkānaṃ vitakkasaṅkhārasaṅghānaṃ manasikaroto upapajjanteva pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā dante'bhidantamādhāya¹⁰ jivhāya tāluṃ āhacca cetasā cittaṃ abhiniggaṇhitabbam abhinippīletabbam abhisantāpetabbam. tassa dante'bhidantamādhāya jivhāya tāluṃ āhacca cetasā cittaṃ abhiniggaṇhato abhinippīlayato abhisantāpayato ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te pahīyanti. te abbattham gacchantī. tesam pahānā ajjhattameva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

¹⁰ dantehi dantamādhāya, bahusu. dante + abhidantaṃ + ādhāyāti ṭikāyaṃ padacchedo. dantehi panettha karaṇattho vutto viya dissati - machasaṃ. dante'bhidantamādhāyāti heṭṭhā dante uparidantaṃ ṭhapetvā aṭṭhakathā-siridhammārāma suddhi

12. Just as, O bhikkhus, a strong man having seized a weaker man by the head, or having seized him by the shoulder, were to forcibly restrain, completely crush, and overwhelm him. So too, O bhikkhus, if for that bhikkhu paying attention to stilling the thought activities of those thoughts, there still arises evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, then O bhikkhus, that bhikkhu, having clenched the teeth together, having pressed the tongue against the palate, should forcibly restrain, completely crush down, overwhelm mental states with mental states. Of him having clenched the teeth together, having pressed the tongue against the palate, forcibly restraining, completely crushing down, overwhelming mental states with mental states, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear. From their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi.

seyyathāpi bhikkhave balavā puriso dubbalataraṃ purisaṃ sīsevā gahetvā khandhe vā gahetvā abhiniggaṇheyya abhinippīleyya abhisantāpeyya, evameva kho bhikkhave tassa ce bhikkhuno tesampi vitakkānaṃ vitakkasaṅkhārasaṅghānaṃ manasikaroto uppajjanteva pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tena bhikkhave bhikkhunā dante'bhidantamādhāya jivhāya tāluṃ āhacca cetasā cittaṃ abhiniggaṇhato abhinippīlayato abhisantāpayato ye pāpakā

akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, te pahīyanti. te abbhataṃ gacchanti. tesam pahānā ajjhataṃ eva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

13. “From the time, O bhikkhus, for a bhikkhu, whatever sign owing to the attention of which there arises evil, unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion, that bhikkhu [withdrawing] from that sign, attending to some other sign connected with the wholesome, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned and disappear, and from their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi;

yato kho bhikkhave bhikkhuno yaṃ nimittaṃ āgamma yaṃ nimittaṃ manasikaroto uppajjanti pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi, tassa tamhā nimittā aññaṃ nimittaṃ manasikaroto kusalūpasamhitam ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi te pahīyanti. te abbhataṃ gacchanti. tesam pahānā ajjhataṃ eva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

14. also of him investigating the danger of those thoughts,

those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned and disappear, and from their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi;

tesampi vitakkānaṃ ādīnavaṃ upaparikkhato ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi do-sūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi te pahīyanti. te abbhattham gacchanti tesam pahānā ajjhataṃ eva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

15. also of him engaging in not being mindful, not attending to those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned and disappear, and from their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi;

tesampi vitakkānaṃ asati amanasikāraṃ āpajjato ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi do-sūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi te pahīyanti. te abbhattham gacchanti tesam pahānā ajjhataṃ eva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

16. also of him paying attention to stilling the thought

activities of those thoughts, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned, they disappear, and from their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi;

tesampi vitakkānaṃ vitakkasaṅkhārasanthānaṃ manasikaroto ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi te pahīyanti. te abbhatthaṃ gacchanti tesam pahānā ajjhattameva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

17. also of him having clenched the teeth together, having pressed the tongue against the palate, forcibly restraining, completely crushing down, overwhelming mental states with mental states, those evil unwholesome thoughts connected with desire, also connected with hatred, also connected with delusion get abandoned and disappear, and from their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samadhi;

dante'bhidantamādhāya¹¹ jivahāya tāluṃ āhacca cetasā cittaṃ abhiniggaṇhato abhinippīlayato abhisantāpayato ye pāpakā akusalā vitakkā chandūpasamhitāpi dosūpasamhitāpi mohūpasamhitāpi

¹¹dantehi dantamādhāya - syā, machasaṃ

te pahīyanti. te abbattham gacchanti tesam pahānā ajjhattameva cittaṃ santiṭṭhati sannisīdati ekodi hoti samādhīyati.

18. this is called, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu who is the master of the pathways of thoughts. Whichever thoughts he wishes to think, it is just those thoughts that he thinks. Whichever thoughts he does not wish to think, it is just those thoughts that he does not think. He has utterly severed thirsting, disjoined the fetters, and rightly breaking through to conceit, has made an end of suffering.”

ayaṃ vuccati bhikkhave bhikkhu vasī vitakkapariyāyapathesu: yaṃ vitakkaṃ ākaṅkhissati taṃ vitakkaṃ vitakkessati, yaṃ vitakkaṃ nākaṅkhissati na taṃ vitakkaṃ vitakkessati, acchecchi taṇhaṃ, vāvattayi¹² saṃyojanaṃ, sammā mānābhisamayā antamakāsi dukkhassāti.

19. This is what the Auspicious One said. Delighted, those bhikkhus rejoiced in the Auspicious One’s words.

idamavoca bhagavā. attamanā te bhikkhū bhagavato bhāsitaṃ abhinandunti.

¹²vivantayi - machasaṃ ■

